Archaeology and history

1. Read the article once for meaning. 2. Read it again and look at the **highlighted new words** and the **blue phrases** in context. 3. Study the tables. 4. Use at least 5 new words in speaking or writing this week.

Article: Digging up the past (176 words)

Archaeology is the study of the human past through what people left behind. Each **excavation** begins with careful planning, because a site can be destroyed by the very work that reveals it. Teams may **unearth** a broken **artifact**, the foundation of a lost **settlement**, or the **ancient** **ruins** of a great city. A single **inscription** can identify a ruler, and a **tomb** may contain objects that tell experts how people lived and what they believed.

Dating is crucial. **Carbon dating** allows scientists to estimate the age of organic remains, while patterns of trade help them follow a **trade route** across a continent. Studies of a powerful **empire** or a long-lived **dynasty** often show how a mighty **civilization** rose, expanded after a successful **conquest** or **invasion**, and finally entered a period of **decline**. Written **chronicle** records, though valuable, can be biased, so archaeologists compare them with physical evidence.

Dry conditions often help to **preserve** fragile material. Whatever its age, each discovery adds to the **legacy** of a distant **era** and reminds us that history is **pieced together** from fragments.

Useful phrases from the article

PHRASE	MEANING
pieced together	slowly assembled

The 20 new words

WORD		MEANING	EXAMPLE
excavation	n	digging to find old objects	*The excavation revealed a Roman road.*
artifact	n	an object made by people long ago	*The artifact is over two thousand years old.*
ancient	adj	very old, from long ago	*Ancient cities were built near rivers.*
civilization	n	an advanced society	*The Mayan civilization was highly developed.*
settlement	n	a place where people start to live	*The first settlement was near the lake.*
ruins	n	the broken remains of buildings	*Tourists visit the ruins every summer.*
dynasty	n	a line of rulers from one family	*The dynasty ruled for three hundred years.*
empire	n	a group of countries ruled by one power	*The Roman Empire controlled much of Europe.*

trade route	n	a path used for buying and selling goods	*The Silk Road was a famous trade route.*
inscription	n	writing carved on stone	*The inscription tells of a great battle.*
tomb	n	a place where a dead person is buried	*The tomb contained gold jewelry.*
carbon dating	n	a way to find the age of old things	*Carbon dating showed the bones were ancient.*
preserve	v	to keep in good condition	*The dry climate preserved the paintings.*
decline	n	a slow fall in strength	*The decline of the empire began in the fifth century.*
conquer	v	to take control by force	*The army conquered the northern lands.*
invasion	n	an attack to take another country	*The invasion changed the language of the region.*
chronicle	n	a record of events in order	*A monk wrote the chronicle.*
legacy	n	something left from the past	*The legacy of Rome is seen in law.*
era	n	a long period of history	*The era of the steam engine began in the 1700s.*
unearth	v	to find by digging	*They unearthed a gold coin.*

Revision: 10 words from last week

WORD		MEANING
assignment	n	a piece of work given to a student
deadline	n	the last time to finish something
tutorial	n	a small class with a tutor
seminar	n	a class where students discuss a topic
dissertation	n	a long piece of writing for a degree
bibliography	n	a list of books used in a piece of work
plagiarism	n	using someone's work as your own
reference	n	a source mentioned in an essay
supervisor	n	a teacher who guides a research project
questionnaire	n	a list of questions for collecting information

Practice: fill the gaps

tomb · settlement · ruins · invasion · artifact · empire · preserve · ancient

1. The _____ contained gold jewelry.
2. The first _____ was near the lake.

3. Tourists visit the _____ every summer.
4. The _____ changed the language of the region.
5. The _____ is over two thousand years old.
6. The Roman _____ controlled much of Europe.
7. The dry climate _____ the paintings.
8. _____ cities were built near rivers.

More words on this topic (not in the article: choose the 10 most useful for you)

ancestor (n): a person from whom you descend
anthropology (n): the study of humans and cultures
bronze (n): a metal made from copper and tin
burial (n): the act of putting a body in a grave
castle (n): a large fortified building
cave painting (n): an ancient picture in a cave
century (n): a hundred years
ceramics (n): objects made from clay
coin (n): a piece of metal money
conquest (n): taking control by force
cradle (n): the place where something began
cultural (adj): connected with a way of life
decipher (v): to read something written in code
fossil (n): the remains of an ancient living thing
hieroglyph (n): a picture used as writing
Iron Age (n): a period when iron was used
medieval (adj): of the Middle Ages
mound (n): a small hill of earth
mummy (n): a preserved body
myth (n): a traditional story
nomadic (adj): moving from place to place
pharaoh (n): a ruler of ancient Egypt
prehistoric (adj): before written records
pyramid (n): a large ancient stone building
relic (n): an object from the past
site (n): a place where something happened
Stone Age (n): an early period of human history
temple (n): a building for worship
tribe (n): a group of people with one culture
vessel (n): a container, such as a pot

Answers

1. tomb (tomb)
2. settlement (settlement)
3. ruins (ruins)
4. invasion (invasion)
5. artifact (artifact)
6. Empire (empire)
7. preserved (preserve)
8. Ancient (ancient)